WITHOUT A TRACE

When a catastrophe strikes a ship at sea and she goes to the bottom, there is usually some clue to her fate - a bit of debris or perhaps a floating life jacket. Five years after her sinking, a life jacket from the *Lusitania* was found, for example, floating along a wharf in Philadelphia - thousands of miles from where the ship went down in 1915. But in the case of the British freighter *Waratah,* and that of the US Navy collier *Cyclops,* no clues have ever been brought forward. The 16,800-ton *Waratah,* only a year old, was last sighted off the coast of South Africa in 1909. The ship had been described by some as top-heavy and may have flipped over in heavy seas; with her vanished 211 people. Equally mystifying is the disappearance of the *Cyclops,* a 19,000-ton ship with 309 people aboard, about seven months before the end of World War I. She was last heard from in March 1918 while en route to Baltimore from the West Indies. Since no logical explanation has ever been offered for her disappearance, the US Navy file on the *Cyclops* has never been closed.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

COLUMN A **COLUMN B**

a) a sudden event that causes great damage .....

b) happen suddenly to something .....

c) something that helps to find the answer to a problem .....

d) the end of something; what happened to something .....

e) scattered fragments of something that has been destroyed .....

f) a place where ships can be tied up to load or unload .....

g) a ship for carrying goods .....

h) a ship for carrying coal .....

i) (be) shown or made public *(phrasal verb)* .....

j) having too much weight on the top and not enough on the bottom .....

k) turn so that the bottom is on top *(phrasal verb)* .....

l) disappear .....

m) on the way somewhere *(phrase)* .....

n) sensible; reasonable .....

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. We learn from the passage that when a ship sinks.....

A) it often creates a small-scale environmental disaster
B) there are usually no signs of it until several years later
C) the passengers are sometimes not rescued for several years
D) there is generally some evidence about what happened to it
E) most of its contents float on the sea for many years

2. The *Waratah* and the *Cyclops* are interesting in that.....

A) despite being from different countries, they caused each other to disappear
B) nobody knows anything about what happened to them, though they were big ships
C) though the *Waratah* was a passenger ship, the *Cyclops,* which wasn't, lost more people
D) the people who know what happened to them are unwilling to tell anyone
E) they both disappeared at exactly the same place, though on different dates

3. Since what happened to the *Cyclops* is unknown.....

A) we must assume that it was sunk by an enemy vessel during the war
B) it's quite obvious that the crew weren't wearing their life jackets
C) the investigation into its disappearance has never been formally ended
D) it would be wrong to assume that the 211 men on board are dead
E) the best explanation would be that it was a poorly-designed ship

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. After the explosion the.....of destroyed buildings was found all over the city.
2. The most difficult part of making an omelette is when it's time to.....it..... so that the other side can be cooked - doing this without ruining it takes a lot of skill.
3. The legendary baseballer Babe Ruth had a very strange physique - he was quite ....., as his massive arms were much bigger than his spindly legs.
4. Things such as pens, calculators, and note pads just seem to.....in this office if you don't keep an eye on them - I don't know if they're being "borrowed" by other employees, or thrown away by the janitor.
5. Pan American flight 103 was.....to New York from Germany when the explosion occurred, killing a total of 270 people.